CSIS JAPAN CHAIR

Japan Daily Brief

Monday, October 12, 2026

1,323 words · 5 min read

RE: DPRK fires ballistic missiles into Sea of Japan · Thales Japan base · nuclear submarine study · immigration cap pressure · energy security

NIKKEI 225	USD/JPY	BRENT	BOJ RATE
69,030.92	158.62	$105.78	1.00%
▼ -1.31%	▲ +0.42%	▲ +5.57%	

TOP STORIES

DPRK

North Korea fires multiple ballistic missiles into Sea of Japan

North Korea launched multiple ballistic missiles into the Sea of Japan, with South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff confirming the launch; at least two of the weapons were assessed to have fallen in waters outside Japan's exclusive economic zone. The launch follows North Korea's hypersonic IRBM test earlier this month — personally overseen by Kim Jong Un — which Pyongyang claimed flew *1,000 km* with AI-guided evasive maneuvers.

THE JAPAN TIMES

DEFENSE

原潜導入へ研究着手案　是非の議論へ、官邸の意向？政府内に慎重論も

Asahi Shimbun reported a draft government plan to initiate a formal study on acquiring nuclear-powered submarines, with the initiative attributed to Kantei intent, though internal government caution is also noted. No Cabinet decision has been confirmed; the report frames the move as a preliminary step toward a policy debate.

ASAHI

DEFENSE

French defense firm Thales to build Japan base, media report says

Patrice Caine, chairman and CEO of Thales, told the Nikkei that the planned Japan base "will mark a milestone toward Thales's long-term engagement in Japan." The move by a major European defense electronics and systems integrator reflects broadening non-US defense industrial investment in Japan as Tokyo expands procurement and co-production partnerships.

THE JAPAN TIMES

POLITICS/DIET

Japan PM faces calls for immigration cap as she weighs policy on foreigners

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is facing political pressure to establish a ceiling on immigration as her government deliberates over a broader foreigners policy, according to Nikkei Asia. The portfolio is assigned to

Minister for Economic Security **Kimi Onoda**, who also holds the foreign residents policy coordination brief.

NIKKEI ASIA

ENERGY

Japan urges oil stockpiling and development as Mideast risks rise

Japan's trade minister called for expanded oil stockpiling and accelerated upstream development abroad to reduce Asia's exposure to Middle East supply disruptions, as Brent crude trades at *$105.78* per barrel. MOFA separately issued a formal statement on Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia, underscoring the dual security and energy dimensions of Gulf instability for Tokyo.

THE JAPAN TIMES

INDO-PACIFIC

US, China and Japan cut foreign aid to South-East Asia as development finance plummets - ABC News & Headlines – Australian Broadcasting Corporation

Japan, the United States, and China have each reduced foreign aid flows to Southeast Asia amid a broader plunge in regional development finance, according to ABC Australia. The simultaneous drawdown by all three major donors narrows the financial space available to ASEAN governments and affects Japan's soft-power and strategic-engagement posture in the region.

ABC.NET.AU

STAT OF THE DAY

4-1

Japan's margin over Russia in World Judo mixed team final, Baku

Japan claimed its eighth mixed team world championship title in Baku, beating Russia 4-1 in the final — a result carrying symbolic weight given the state of Japan-Russia relations.

Mainichi / Kyodo, October 12, 2026

JAPANESE GOVERNMENT

KANTEI/PM · CABINET · MOFA · MOD · METI · MOF · BOJ · DIET · MONDAY, OCTOBER 12, 2026

PM Watch: No confirmed PM appearance today · 1 day(s) since last confirmed appearance

外務省 · MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

MOFA issues statement condemning Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia

Japan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs published a formal statement regarding Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia, consistent with Japan's dependence on Gulf energy supplies and its stated policy of supporting regional stability in the Middle East.

→ Google News ↗

DIET SESSIONS / LDP

JAPANESE COMMUNIST PARTY

JCP revises next lower-house election vote target down to 4.5 million — achievement described as uncertain

The Japanese Communist Party lowered its target for proportional representation votes in the next House of Representatives election to 4.5 million, a downward revision from its previous goal, with party leadership acknowledging the target remains out of reach on current trajectories.

LDP

LDP senior figure publicly opposes Takaichi consumption tax cut, citing fiscal sustainability

A senior LDP figure described by Asahi as the party's 'last boss' on fiscal matters stated opposition to the consumption tax reduction plan, arguing it would 'devour fiscal resources' with no alternative identified. Internal LDP resistance to the flagship policy is now on the record ahead of Diet deliberations.

PUBLIC SENTIMENT & APPROVAL POLLING

POLLSTER	APPROVE	DISAPPROVE
JNN · Oct 4, 2026	**63%**	**33.9%**
Asahi · Sep 28, 2026	**51%**	**33%**
ANN · Sep 23, 2026	**58.3%**	**27.6%**
Kyodo · Sep 23, 2026	**53.4%**	**30.9%**
Nikkei · Sep 5, 2026 **· 37d ago**	**62%**	**33%**
Yomiuri · Sep 19, 2026 **· 23d ago**	**59%**	**30%**
FNN · Sep 15, 2026 **· 27d ago**	**61.6%**	**32.2%**
NHK · Sep 10, 2026 **· 32d ago**	**52.8%**	**30.8%**

Discourse: An LDP senior figure publicly opposed Prime Minister Takaichi's flagship consumption tax cut plan, citing fiscal sustainability concerns, adding internal party friction to Diet deliberations on the bill already submitted in October.

Poll tracker: **Observing Japan approval-rating aggregator →**

BUSINESS & ECONOMY

SEMICONDUCTORS · NIKKEI ASIA · APPLE (HISTORICAL), UNSPECIFIED OPERATOR

Former iPhone display plant in Japan repurposed for semiconductor supply chain role

A former iPhone display manufacturing facility in Japan is being converted to serve the chip supply chain, adding domestic semiconductor manufacturing capacity outside the Rapidus and TSMC Kumamoto (JASM) projects. Nikkei Asia did not specify the operator or output volume in the available summary.

FINANCE · NIKKEI ASIA

Investors shift into Japan and Australia rental housing as rates and home prices climb

Institutional and retail investors are increasing allocations to rental housing in Japan and Australia as rising interest rates and home prices suppress owner-occupier demand and increase rental yields. The trend reflects ongoing repricing of Japanese real estate assets as the Bank of Japan's policy rate holds at *1.00%*.

MACRO · NIKKEI ASIA

Japan monetizes academic brand overseas, building education export industry

Japanese institutions and companies are developing frameworks to export Japan's educational model and academic credentials internationally, according to Nikkei Asia. The effort targets both revenue generation and soft-power expansion at a time when Japan is also actively managing inbound foreign student and worker flows.

REGIONAL PRESSURE WATCH WATCH

Tier 4 scrapers returned 0 articles; DPRK launch reported via Japan Times (Tier 1)

CHINA

No new Tier 4 China Coast Guard or PLA activity data collected today. Prior tracker: four CCG vessels entered Senkaku territorial waters October 10; Beijing's protocol-slight campaign against PM Takaichi continues. No update available from today's scrape.

NORTH KOREA

North Korea fired multiple ballistic missiles into the Sea of Japan; at least two fell outside Japan's EEZ. South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff confirmed the launch. The event follows the hypersonic IRBM test in early October and multiple short- and medium-range launches in recent weeks.

RUSSIA

No new Tier 4 Russia data collected today. Prior tracker: Japan protested Russia's ICC extradition request (October 9-10); TASS reporting on Japan's shadow-fleet sanctions and peace treaty signals ongoing. No update from today's scrape.

Senkaku / ECS: No new data from today's scrape. Prior baseline: near-daily CCG contiguous-zone patrols with periodic territorial-water intrusions; four CCG vessels entered territorial waters October 10.

Bottom line: The DPRK ballistic missile launch into the Sea of Japan is the dominant adversary signal today, confirmed via Tier 1 press. Tier 4 scrapers returned zero articles — China and Russia signals carried forward from tracker history only.

INDO-PACIFIC PARTNERS

SOUTHEAST ASIA · MAINICHI

Japan cross-party parliamentary group head thanks Taiwan President Lai for post-disaster support

Keiji Furuya, leader of a cross-party Diet group promoting Japan-Taiwan friendship, met Taiwan President Lai Ching-te in Taipei and thanked him for support following recent disasters in Japan.

UPCOMING

Oct **North Korea ballistic missile launches — Japan monitoring posture elevated**

12

Multiple ballistic missiles fired into the Sea of Japan overnight; at least two believed to have fallen outside Japan's EEZ. Japan's MOD and Joint Staff are assessing trajectory and payload data.

Nov 3

Culture Day (文化の日)

The 1946 constitution was promulgated on this date.

Dec 25

Japan's DBS-equivalent background check system launches

A Japanese version of Britain's Disclosure and Barring Service is set to launch December 25, with cram schools among the first institutions required to obtain anti-sexual assault certification under the new framework.

Jan 1

Diet ordinary session — expected to convene

Japan's ordinary Diet session typically opens in January for approximately 150 days; the consumption tax cut bill submitted in October and the defense budget will be central agenda items. Verify exact opening date from official announcements.

Mar 31

Host-Nation Support Special Measures Agreement expiration

The current SMA governing Japan's host-nation support contribution (~¥211 billion/year) expires March 31, 2027; negotiations on the successor agreement will intensify in early 2027.

CSIS Japan Chair

JAPAN DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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